

My Old Home

Tao Yuanming · 陶淵明

雜詩十二首 · 其七

日 月 不 肯 遲
四 時 相 催 迫
寒 風 拂 枯 條
落 葉 掩 長 陌
弱 質 與 運 頽
玄 鬢 早 已 白
素 標 插 人 頭
前 途 漸 窄
家 為 逆 旅 舍
我 如 當 去 客
去 山 欲 何 之
南 有 舊 宅

ENGLISH · Burton Watson

Sun and moon refuse to slow their pace
the four seasons press and hurry each other onward.
Cold wind shakes the bare branches,
fallen leaves blanket the long lane.
Weak by nature, I feel myself decay with time's passing,
the black hair at my temples already turned white.
Flecks of gray find their way into my head,
signs that the road ahead will grow more and more narrow.
What is a house but an inn on a journey,
and I a traveler who must keep moving on?
Move on, move on--and where will I go?
My old home is there on the southern mountain.

HOW TO FOLLOW THE STEPS. Numbered panels run left to right, then continue on the next row. Bright red is the new stroke; gray is completed; pale gray is still to come. White dot = start; white arrow = finish/direction. Lift between panels, not at every bend.

READING & SOUND. This edition reads left to right. Traditional vertical Chinese reads downward in columns from right to left. Pinyin and audio use modern Mandarin, not ancient pronunciation. Recordings are synthetic, at 60% of the reference speed. Print double-sided, flip on the long edge.

English wording follows your National Gallery exhibition script, p. 6; attributed to Burton Watson, *The Columbia Book of Chinese Poetry* (1984), p. 137. My Old Home is a descriptive title. Full provenance accompanies this edition. Models: modern regular script, not the poet's handwriting. Stroke conventions can vary; sources and licenses are in Workbook Sources.

My Old Home — line 1

Tao Yuanming · English: Burton Watson

日月不肯遲

Sun and moon refuse to slow their pace

Sun and moon + refuse + to slow. The passing days are personified; Watson supplies 'their pace'.

日

rì

4 strokes

Sun; day. With 月 forms the subject. The celestial body also evokes the passage of days.

Form. Keep the box upright; place the middle bar inside before closing the bottom.

日 日 日 日

1

2

3

4

月

yuè

4 strokes

Moon; month. Completes 日月, “sun and moon” or, by extension, the passing days and months.

Form. Let the left stroke curve gently; leave breathing room between the two inner bars.

月 月 月 月

1

2

3

4

不

bù

4 strokes

Not. Negates 肯.

Form. Balance the long top bar, left-falling stroke, central vertical, and final dot.

不 不 不 不

1

2

3

4

肯

kěn

8 strokes

Be willing; consent. 不肯 means “will not” or “refuse to,” personifying time as unwilling to wait.

Form. Keep the upper part centered above the compact lower enclosure.

肯 肯 肯 肯 肯 肯 肯 肯

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

遲

chí

15 strokes

Be slow; delay. What sun and moon will not do. It functions as a verb or descriptive predicate, not a noun.

Form. Build the dense inner part first; the walking component wraps around it last.

遲 遲 遲 遲 遲 遲 遲 遲

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

遲 遲 遲 遲 遲 遲 遲 遲

9

10

11

12

13

14

15

My Old Home — line 1

Tao Yuanming · English: Burton Watson

日月不肯遲

Sun and moon refuse to slow their pace

Sun and moon + refuse + to slow. The passing days are personified; Watson supplies 'their pace'.

日

rì
4 strokes

日

日

日

日

日

日

月

yuè
4 strokes

月

月

月

月

月

月

不

bù
4 strokes

不

不

不

不

不

不

肯

kěn
8 strokes

肯

肯

肯

肯

肯

肯

遲

chí
15 strokes

遲

遲

遲

遲

遲

遲

My Old Home — line 2

Tao Yuanming · English: Burton Watson

四時相催迫

the four seasons press and hurry each other onward.

Four seasons + mutually + hurry and press. Two verbs make the natural succession feel urgent.

四

sì

5 strokes

Four. Specifies the number of seasons.

Form. Write the outer sides, then the two inner strokes; close the bottom last.

四 四 四 四 四

1

2

3

4

5

時

shí

10 strokes

Season; time. 四時 is the established expression for the year's four seasons, the subject.

Form. Keep the left sun component narrow and the right component more spacious.

時 時 時 時 時 時 時 時 時 時

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

9

10

相

xiāng

9 strokes

Mutually; one another. Makes the action reciprocal, not something done by an outside agent to the seasons.

Form. Fit the narrow tree at left beside the upright eye-shaped box at right.

相 相 相 相 相 相 相 相 相

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

9

催

cuī

13 strokes

Urge on; hurry. First part of the main verb expression.

Form. Keep the person component slim; stack the mountain above the right-hand body.

催 催 催 催 催 催 催

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

催 催 催 催 催 催

8

9

10

11

12

13

迫

pò

8 strokes

Press; compel; drive closely. Reinforces 催: the seasons hurry and press one another onward.

Form. Complete the white component first, then the walking component around it.

迫 迫 迫 迫 迫 迫 迫 迫

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

My Old Home — line 2

Tao Yuanming · English: Burton Watson

四時相催迫

the four seasons press and hurry each other onward.

Four seasons + mutually + hurry and press. Two verbs make the natural succession feel urgent.

四

sì
5 strokes

四 四 四 四 四 四 四

時

shí
10 strokes

時 時 時 時 時 時 時

相

xiāng
9 strokes

相 相 相 相 相 相 相

催

cuī
13 strokes

催 催 催 催 催 催 催

迫

pò
8 strokes

迫 迫 迫 迫 迫 迫 迫

My Old Home — line 3

Tao Yuanming · English: Burton Watson

寒風拂枯條

Cold wind shakes the bare branches,

Cold wind + brushes + withered branches. The season is suggested by the scene, not named.

寒

hán
12 strokes

Cold. Qualifies 風.

Form. Center the stacked middle beneath the roof; finish with the two low dots.

寒 寒 寒 寒 寒 寒 寒 寒 寒 寒 寒 寒

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

9

10

11

12

風

fēng
9 strokes

Wind. Subject of 拂.

Form. Keep the inner strokes within the broad outer sweep without crowding them.

風 風 風 風 風 風 風 風 風

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

9

拂

fú
8 strokes

Brush against; sweep over; stir. Main verb. Watson's "shakes" is stronger than the most basic "brushes."

Form. Keep the hand component narrow; make room for the turns and verticals at right.

拂 拂 拂 拂 拂 拂 拂 拂

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

枯

kū
9 strokes

Withered; dried; bare of living growth. Qualifies 條.

Form. Balance a narrow tree at left with the upright cross and box at right.

枯 枯 枯 枯 枯 枯 枯 枯 枯

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

9

條

tiáo
11 strokes

Branch; twig. Object of 拂. Here it is a thing, not the modern counting word used before long objects.

Form. Leave clear gaps among the narrow left strokes and the stacked right-hand parts.

條 條 條 條 條 條 條 條 條 條 條

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

9

10

11

My Old Home — line 3

Tao Yuanming · English: Burton Watson

寒風拂枯條

Cold wind shakes the bare branches,

Cold wind + brushes + withered branches. The season is suggested by the scene, not named.

寒 寒 寒 寒 寒 寒 寒

hán
12 strokes

風 風 風 風 風 風 風

fēng
9 strokes

拂 拂 拂 拂 拂 拂 拂

fú
8 strokes

枯 枯 枯 枯 枯 枯 枯

kū
9 strokes

條 條 條 條 條 條 條

tiáo
11 strokes

My Old Home — line 4

Tao Yuanming · English: Burton Watson

落葉掩長陌

fallen leaves blanket the long lane.

Fallen leaves + cover + the long path. This physical lane anticipates the later road of remaining life.

落

luò
12 strokes

Fallen; falling. Qualifies 葉 to form the subject “fallen leaves.”

Form. Spread the grass top across the water component and the lower-right structure.

落 落 落 落 落 落 落 落 落 落 落 落

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

9

10

11

12

葉

yè
13 strokes

Leaf; leaves. Head of the subject.

Form. Keep the grass top compact; let the lower tree strokes support the middle.

葉 葉 葉 葉 葉 葉 葉

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

9

10

11

12

13

掩

yǎn
11 strokes

Cover; conceal. Main verb; “blanket” is Watson’s vivid English equivalent.

Form. Keep the hand component slim; allow the broad right-hand part to open out.

掩 掩 掩 掩 掩 掩 掩 掩 掩 掩 掩

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

9

10

11

長

cháng
8 strokes

Long. Qualifies 陌.

Form. Separate the close upper bars and give the long lower sweep enough room.

長 長 長 長 長 長 長 長

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

陌

mò
8 strokes

Path; field-road; lane. Object of 掩, the route covered by leaves.

Form. Keep the left ear-shaped component narrow; center the hundred component at right.

陌 陌 陌 陌 陌 陌 陌 陌

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

My Old Home — line 4

Tao Yuanming · English: Burton Watson

落葉掩長陌

fallen leaves blanket the long lane.

Fallen leaves + cover + the long path. This physical lane anticipates the later road of remaining life.

落 落 落 落 落 落 落

luò
12 strokes

葉 葉 葉 葉 葉 葉 葉

yè
13 strokes

掩 掩 掩 掩 掩 掩 掩

yǎn
11 strokes

長 長 長 長 長 長 長

cháng
8 strokes

陌 陌 陌 陌 陌 陌 陌

mò
8 strokes

My Old Home — line 5

Tao Yuanming · English: Burton Watson

弱質與運頹

Weak by nature, I feel myself decay with time's passing,

[My] frail constitution + with time's course + declines. Bodily weakness, not a moral judgment; Watson makes the personal experience explicit.

弱

ruò
10 strokes

Weak; frail. Qualifies 質.

Form. Balance the two bent forms; keep their small lower strokes distinct.

弱 弱 弱 弱 弱 弱 弱 弱 弱 弱

質

zhì
15 strokes

Constitution; bodily substance; inherent make-up. 弱質 refers here to the speaker's frail person or body, the subject.

Form. Balance the paired upper parts above the shell component; leave its inner bars clear.

質 質 質 質 質 質 質 質
質 質 質 質 質 質 質 質

與

yǔ
13 strokes

With; along with. Introduces what the decline accompanies. It is not “give” here.

Form. Follow the numbered interlocking strokes carefully; do not treat the top as a closed box.

與 與 與 與 與 與 與
與 與 與 與 與 與 與

運

yùn
12 strokes

Course; turning or passage; allotment of time or fortune. Here the course of time or one's life, accompanying the body's decline.

Form. Build the capped inner component first; finish with the enclosing walking component.

運 運 運 運 運 運 運 運 運 運 運 運

頹

tuí
16 strokes

Decline; deteriorate; fall away. Main predicate of 弱質.

Form. Balance the grain-and-legs structure at left with the page-shaped component at right.

頹 頹 頹 頹 頹 頹 頹 頹
頹 頹 頹 頹 頹 頹 頹 頹

My Old Home — line 5

Tao Yuanming · English: Burton Watson

弱質與運頹

Weak by nature, I feel myself decay with time's passing,

[My] frail constitution + with time's course + declines. Bodily weakness, not a moral judgment; Watson makes the personal experience explicit.

弱

ruò
10 strokes

弱 弱 弱 弱 弱 弱 弱

質

zhì
15 strokes

質 質 質 質 質 質 質

與

yǔ
13 strokes

與 與 與 與 與 與 與

運

yùn
12 strokes

運 運 運 運 運 運 運

頹

tuí
16 strokes

頹 頹 頹 頹 頹 頹 頹

My Old Home — line 6

Tao Yuanming · English: Burton Watson

玄 鬢 早 已 白

the black hair at my temples already turned white.

Black temple-hair + long since already + [has become] white. Some editions have 'hair' rather than 'temple-hair'; this follows the existing guide.

玄

xuán
5 strokes

Black; very dark. Qualifies 鬢. It is not “mysterious” in this phrase.

Form. Center the top dot and bar above the two lower turns and final dot.

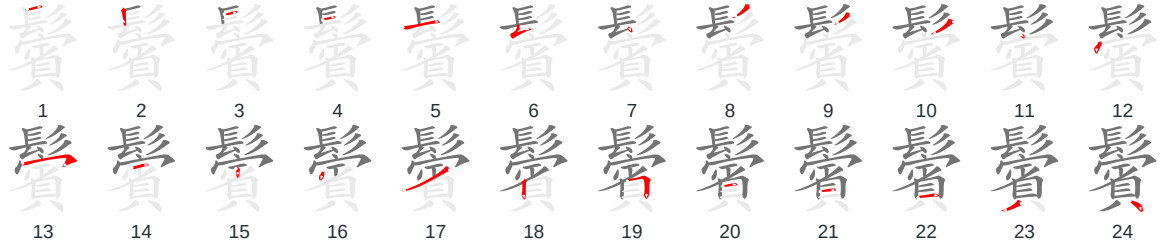


鬢

bìn
24 strokes

Hair at the temples. Head of the subject: the once-black temple-hair.

Form. Keep the hair component above the dense lower part; use both rows of steps in sequence.

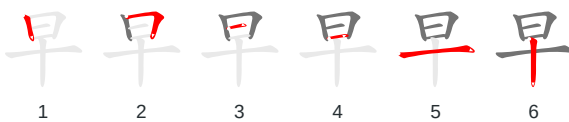


早

zǎo
6 strokes

Early; long since. Adds that the change has occurred already, earlier than the speaker might wish.

Form. Center the sun-shaped box over the lower cross; keep both upright.



已

yǐ
3 strokes

Already. Marks the state as attained. 早已 works together as “long since/already.”

Form. Notice how high the final turn rises at left; this distinguishes similar-looking forms.



白

bái
5 strokes

White; become white. Predicate of 鬢. English supplies “turned” or “become.”

Form. Place the short slant above the box; keep the interior bar separate from its base.



My Old Home — line 6

Tao Yuanming · English: Burton Watson

玄 鬢 早 已 白

the black hair at my temples already turned white.

Black temple-hair + long since already + [has become] white. Some editions have 'hair' rather than 'temple-hair'; this follows the existing guide.

玄 玄 玄 玄 玄 玄 玄

xuán
5 strokes

鬢 鬢 鬢 鬢 鬢 鬢 鬢

bìn
24 strokes

早 早 早 早 早 早 早

zǎo
6 strokes

已 已 已 已 已 已 已

yǐ
3 strokes

白 白 白 白 白 白 白

bái
5 strokes

My Old Home — line 7

Tao Yuanming · English: Burton Watson

素標插入頭

Flecks of gray find their way into my head,

A white marker + is planted in + one's head. Watson unpacks white hair as a sign of age across this and the following line; no particular funeral object is named.

素

sù
10 strokes

White; uncolored. Qualifies 標. It does not mean “vegetarian” or “simple living” here.

Form. Center the narrow upper stack over the silk-shaped lower part and its spreading strokes.

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

標

biāo
15 strokes

Mark; marker; sign. Head of 素標, “white marker,” referring to white hair as a sign of age.

Form. Keep the left tree slender; align the stacked right-hand parts on one center line.

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8
9 10 11 12 13 14 15

插

chā
12 strokes

Insert; stick into; plant. Main verb. The image is of the marker standing or being stuck in the head.

Form. Keep the hand slim; preserve the small gaps within the mortar-shaped lower-right part.

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12

人

rén
2 strokes

Person; one. Possessor of 頭: “a person’s head.” In context the general wording includes the speaker.

Form. Let the left-falling stroke and right-falling stroke support one another without symmetry.

1 2

頭

tóu
16 strokes

Head. The place into which the marker is set; 人頭 is “one’s head.”

Form. Balance the bean-shaped left side with the taller page-shaped right side.

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8
9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16

My Old Home — line 7

Tao Yuanming · English: Burton Watson

素 標 插 人 頭

Flecks of gray find their way into my head,

A white marker + is planted in + one's head. Watson unpacks white hair as a sign of age across this and the following line; no particular funeral object is named.

素

sù

10 strokes

素 素 素 素 素 素 素

標

biāo

15 strokes

標 標 標 標 標 標 標

插

chā

12 strokes

插 插 插 插 插 插 插

人

rén

2 strokes

人 人 人 人 人 人 人

頭

tóu

16 strokes

頭 頭 頭 頭 頭 頭 頭

My Old Home — line 8

Tao Yuanming · English: Burton Watson

前途漸就窄

signs that the road ahead will grow more and more narrow.

The road ahead + gradually + approaches narrowness. The context is diminishing life, not success or failure in a career.

前

qián
9 strokes

Ahead; in front. Qualifies 途.

Form. Place the paired top marks above the body; leave room for the narrow right-hand knife.

前 前 前 前 前 前 前 前 前

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

9

途

tú
10 strokes

Road; route. 前途 is the road ahead, and by extension the remainder of one's life or future.

Form. Complete the inner part first; let the last walking stroke carry it from below.

途 途 途 途 途 途 途 途 途 途

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

9

10

漸

jiàn
14 strokes

Gradually. Adverb describing the change.

Form. Keep the three water strokes slim; separate the two denser components to their right.

漸 漸 漸 漸 漸 漸 漸

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

漸 漸 漸 漸 漸 漸 漸

8

9

10

11

12

13

14

就

jiù
12 strokes

Approach; move toward; come to. Leads into the state expressed by 窄. It is not the modern conversational “just.”

Form. Balance the tall capital-shaped left part with the open, sweeping strokes at right.

就 就 就 就 就 就 就 就 就 就 就 就

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

9

10

11

12

窄

zhǎi
10 strokes

Narrow. The state toward which the road is moving.

Form. Center the lower part beneath the cave-like roof; keep its short bars parallel.

窄 窄 窄 窄 窄 窄 窄 窄 窄 窄

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

9

10

My Old Home — line 8

Tao Yuanming · English: Burton Watson

前途漸就窄

signs that the road ahead will grow more and more narrow.

The road ahead + gradually + approaches narrowness. The context is diminishing life, not success or failure in a career.

前 前 前 前 前 前 前

qián

9 strokes

途 途 途 途 途 途 途

tú

10 strokes

漸 漸 漸 漸 漸 漸 漸

jiàn

14 strokes

就 就 就 就 就 就 就

jiù

12 strokes

窄 窄 窄 窄 窄 窄 窄

zhǎi

10 strokes

My Old Home — line 9

Tao Yuanming · English: Burton Watson

家為逆旅舍

What is a house but an inn on a journey,

Home + is + a travelers' inn. Read 逆旅 as a compound meaning 'inn', not a backward journey; Watson turns the statement into a question.

家

jiā
10 strokes

Home; household; house. Subject. Here the place of ordinary residence is being reconsidered.

Form. Give the roof a quiet width; let the lower strokes spread without touching it.

家 家 家 家 家 家 家 家 家 家

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

為

wéi
9 strokes

Be; serve as. Links “home” to “inn.” It is not wèi, “for,” here.

Form. This is the nine-stroke 為 form. Follow its three connected bends; add the four dots last.

為 為 為 為 為 為 為 為 為

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9

逆

nì
9 strokes

Meet; receive; welcome. The older sense within 逆旅. It does not make this an “opposite” or “backward” journey.

Form. Form the inner part first; finish the walking component around the lower left.

逆 逆 逆 逆 逆 逆 逆 逆 逆

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9

旅

lǚ
10 strokes

Traveler; traveling. With 逆 forms the established word 逆旅, a place receiving travelers: an inn.

Form. Keep the flag-like left part narrow; balance the longer descending strokes at right.

旅 旅 旅 旅 旅 旅 旅 旅 旅 旅

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

舍

shě
8 strokes

Lodging; dwelling. Completes 逆旅舍, “travelers’ lodging/inn.” It is not shě, “give up.”

Form. Center the opening pair over the middle cross and the small lower box.

舍 舍 舍 舍 舍 舍 舍 舍

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8

My Old Home — line 9

Tao Yuanming · English: Burton Watson

家為逆旅舍

What is a house but an inn on a journey,

Home + is + a travelers' inn. Read 逆旅 as a compound meaning 'inn', not a backward journey; Watson turns the statement into a question.

家

jiā
10 strokes

家家家家家家家

為

wéi
9 strokes

為為為為為為為

逆

nì
9 strokes

逆逆逆逆逆逆逆

旅

lǚ
10 strokes

旅旅旅旅旅旅旅

舍

shě
8 strokes

舍舍舍舍舍舍舍

My Old Home — line 10

Tao Yuanming · English: Burton Watson

我如當去客

and I a traveler who must keep moving on?

I + am like + [about-to-leave + guest]. No separate 'who' is needed in Chinese. The temporary guest answers the temporary lodging.

我

wǒ
7 strokes

I; me. The explicit first-person subject.

Form. Watch the crossing strokes and curved hook; follow the numbered order, not visual layers.

我 我 我 我 我 我 我

1 2 3 4 5 6 7

如

rú
6 strokes

Be like; resemble. Main verb introducing the comparison.

Form. Give the woman component room to cross at left; keep the mouth box compact at right.

如 如 如 如 如 如

1 2 3 4 5 6

當

dāng
13 strokes

Be due to; be about to; must. A modal element modifying 去, the departure.

Form. Center the layered top over the lower field; preserve each small enclosed space.

當 當 當 當 當 當 當

1 2 3 4 5 6 7
8 9 10 11 12 13

去

qù
5 strokes

Leave; depart; go away. With 當 describes the guest who is due to leave.

Form. Center the lower angled form beneath the upright cross and longer middle bar.

去 去 去 去 去

1 2 3 4 5

客

kè
9 strokes

Guest; traveler; sojourner. Object of 如, qualified by 當去: “a guest about to depart.”

Form. Center the crossing middle strokes and lower box under the roof.

客 客 客 客 客 客 客 客 客

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9

My Old Home — line 10

Tao Yuanming · English: Burton Watson

我 如 當 去 客

and I a traveler who must keep moving on?

I + am like + [about-to-leave + guest]. No separate 'who' is needed in Chinese. The temporary guest answers the temporary lodging.

我 我 我 我 我 我 我

wǒ

7 strokes

如 如 如 如 如 如 如

rú

6 strokes

當 當 當 當 當 當 當

dāng

13 strokes

去 去 去 去 去 去 去

qù

5 strokes

客 客 客 客 客 客 客

kè

9 strokes

My Old Home — line 11

Tao Yuanming · English: Burton Watson

去去欲何之

Move on, move on--and where will I go?

Going, going + [I] am to + where + go? The destination precedes its verb. This is a question about departure, not an arrival.

去

qù
5 strokes

Go; depart. Begins the repeated expression of leaving.

Form. Center the lower angled form beneath the upright cross and longer middle bar.

去去去去去
1 2 3 4 5

去

qù
5 strokes

Go on; keep going. Repetition emphasizes departure or continued movement, rather than naming two destinations.

Form. Center the lower angled form beneath the upright cross and longer middle bar.

去去去去去
1 2 3 4 5

欲

yù
11 strokes

Wish to; intend to; be about to. Here it introduces the question of where the departing person is to go.

Form. Balance the valley component at left with the open, falling strokes at right.

欲欲欲欲欲欲欲欲欲欲欲
1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11

何

hé
7 strokes

What?; where? Interrogative destination before the verb 之: “to what place?”

Form. Keep the person component slim; hang the small box beneath the long top-right bar.

何何何何何何何
1 2 3 4 5 6 7

之

zhī
3 strokes

Go to; proceed to. A verb here. It is not the possessive “of,” nor the pronoun “it,” familiar from other classical sentences.

Form. Start with the dot; the turning middle leads to a long, balanced final sweep.

之之之
1 2 3

My Old Home — line 11

Tao Yuanming · English: Burton Watson

去去欲何之

Move on, move on--and where will I go?

Going, going + [I] am to + where + go? The destination precedes its verb. This is a question about departure, not an arrival.

去 去 去 去 去 去 去

qù

5 strokes

去 去 去 去 去 去 去

qù

5 strokes

欲 欲 欲 欲 欲 欲 欲

yù

11 strokes

何 何 何 何 何 何 何

hé

7 strokes

之 之 之 之 之 之 之

zhī

3 strokes

My Old Home — line 12

Tao Yuanming · English: Burton Watson

南山有舊宅

My old home is there on the southern mountain.

At the southern mountain + there is + an old home. 'My' is understood; neither 'reach' nor 'horseback' is written. In context the dwelling is a grave or final resting place, not a claim about an afterlife.

南

nán
9 strokes

South; southern. Qualifies 山.

Form. Center the top cross over the enclosure; leave the small inner strokes uncrowded.

南 南 南 南 南 南 南 南 南

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

9

山

shān
3 strokes

Mountain. 南山 is “South Mountain” or “the southern mountain,” placed first as the location.

Form. Begin with the central upright; the lower turn and right upright establish the base.

山 山 山

1

2

3

有

yǒu
6 strokes

Have; there is. Existential verb: at that place, a dwelling exists. It does not mean “reach.”

Form. Let the top crossing strokes open over the lower moon-shaped component.

有 有 有 有 有 有

1

2

3

4

5

6

舊

jiù
18 strokes

Old; former; long-established. Qualifies 宅.

Form. Stack grass, bird, and mortar components; use both rows of numbered steps.

舊 舊 舊 舊 舊 舊 舊 舊 舊

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

9

10

11

12

13

14

15

16

17

18

宅

zhái
6 strokes

Dwelling; residence; home. The thing that is there, completing 舊宅, “old home.”

Form. Center the compact lower structure beneath the roof; leave room for the final hook.

宅 宅 宅 宅 宅 宅

1

2

3

4

5

6

My Old Home — line 12

Tao Yuanming · English: Burton Watson

南山有舊宅

My old home is there on the southern mountain.

At the southern mountain + there is + an old home. 'My' is understood; neither 'reach' nor 'horseback' is written. In context the dwelling is a grave or final resting place, not a claim about an afterlife.

南 南 南 南 南 南 南

nán

9 strokes

山 山 山 山 山 山 山

shān

3 strokes

有 有 有 有 有 有 有

yǒu

6 strokes

舊 舊 舊 舊 舊 舊 舊

jiù

18 strokes

宅 宅 宅 宅 宅 宅 宅

zhái

6 strokes